WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

VIETNAM

Asia

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Hanoi	Capital and seat of the Party, Government and National Assembly; centre of policy-making and northern gateway to the planned North–South high-speed railway	Government relations, financial services, technology, infrastructure
Greater Ho Chi Minh City	Largest economy and commercial capital, enlarged in 2025 by merger with Binh Duong and Ba Ria–Vung Tau to a metropolis of over 13 million people; host of the Vietnam International Financial Centre's market-infrastructure arm	Financial services, manufacturing, port logistics, real estate, retail
Da Nang	Central coastal city and second seat of the Vietnam International Financial Centre, focused on innovation, green finance and trade finance	Fintech, green finance, tourism, IT services
Northern manufacturing belt (Bac Ninh, Thai Nguyen, Hai Phong)	Leading cluster for electronics and high-tech assembly, linked to Hai Phong's deep-water port and to northern supply chains	Electronics, semiconductors, components, logistics
Dong Nai / Long Thanh	Site of Long Thanh International Airport, proposed to open for commercial operations on 1 December 2026, adjacent to established southern industrial parks	Aviation, air cargo, logistics, industrial real estate
Mekong Delta (Can Tho and surrounding provinces)	Vietnam's agricultural heartland, supplying rice, fruit and seafood to a fast-growing agro-export sector	Agro-processing, aquaculture, cold-chain logistics, renewables
Industrial parks, high-tech zones and economic zones (nationwide)	Designated zones now benefit from an expedited registration route under Decree 96/2026, with Investment Registration Certificates targeted within 15 working days	Manufacturing, export processing, logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Ministry of Finance, which absorbed the former Ministry of Planning and Investment in 2025, together with provincial Departments of Finance, oversees foreign investment and issues Investment Registration and Enterprise Registration Certificates

- Law on Investment No. 143/2025/QH15, in force since 1 March 2026, and its guiding Decree 96/2026/ND-CP, introducing a three-tier special-incentive structure for large projects and a pre-certificate route for establishing a local entity
- Expedited investment procedure for projects in industrial parks and high-tech zones, which bypasses investment policy approval and moves directly to registration
- Vietnam International Financial Centre (Ho Chi Minh City and Da Nang) under Resolution 222/2025/QH15, offering 10% corporate income tax for priority sectors, a liberalised foreign-exchange regime, a choice of foreign law and English as a working language
- State Bank of Vietnam oversight of foreign-exchange and capital-account matters; the dong is managed within a trading band and profits are remitted through licensed bank accounts
- Equity-market entry following FTSE Russell's upgrade of Vietnam to Secondary Emerging market status, effective 21 September 2026
- Sector market-access rules set out in the guiding decree, which lists sectors closed to foreign investors and a wider list of conditional sectors with ownership or licensing requirements

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Vietnam in October 2026 is one of the fastest-growing economies in the world. GDP expanded 9.01% in the first nine months of 2026, accelerating to 9.95% in the third quarter, following 8.02% growth in 2025, with manufacturing (+11.36%) and construction (+12.22%) leading. Foreign investors are responding strongly: registered FDI reached $50.36 billion in the first nine months, up 76.4% year-on-year, while disbursed FDI rose 12.1% to $21.07 billion, the highest nine-month level in five years, after $27.6 billion in 2025. A sweeping reform agenda underpins this momentum, including a new Law on Investment in force since March 2026, a streamlined two-tier administration, the launch of the Vietnam International Financial Centre and FTSE Russell's upgrade to emerging market status from September 2026. Moody's raised Vietnam's outlook to positive in May 2026, citing improving institutions and faster project approvals.

Vietnam's principal structural consideration is the concentration of its export model on the US market and on imported inputs. The US took $140 billion of Vietnamese exports in the first nine months of 2026, and US trade policy has shifted repeatedly: a 10% Section 122 surcharge expired in July 2026 and an additional 12.5% Section 301 duty has applied to Vietnamese goods since 24 July, with further investigations open on intellectual property and excess capacity. Vietnam has responded constructively, with its Deputy Prime Minister holding talks with the US Trade Representative in August 2026 and committing to tighten controls on transshipment. At the same time, its network of trade agreements is broadening demand: the trade surplus with the EU rose 25.3% to $36.06 billion in the first nine months. For investors, rising scrutiny of origin rewards genuine local manufacturing and supplier development, creating opportunities in components, materials and higher value-added production.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
US trade measures	Vietnamese goods face an additional 12.5% Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026, with open US investigations on intellectual property and excess capacity, while bilateral talks on a reciprocal agreement continue	Build tariff scenarios into US-facing projects, document origin rigorously and use Vietnam's EU, CPTPP and RCEP access to diversify sales
Rules-of-origin and transshipment scrutiny	Washington has pressed Vietnam to tighten controls on rerouted goods, and Vietnam has committed to address these concerns	Prioritise genuine local value-added and traceable supply chains, which also positions investors to benefit from stricter enforcement
Import dependence for inputs	Strong investment-led growth drew in imports, producing a $19.42 billion goods deficit in the first nine months of 2026, although September returned to surplus	Supplier-development and component manufacturing investments meet a clear and policy-supported demand for local sourcing
Inflation and currency management	Inflation reached 5.09% year-on-year in October 2026, above the 4.5% target, and the dong has traded near the weaker end of its band	The State Bank has kept its refinancing rate steady at 4.50%; apply standard hedging for significant local-currency exposure

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Administrative transition	The 2025 consolidation from 63 to 34 provinces and the merger of ministries have changed which authorities handle investment procedures	Engage the relevant provincial Department of Finance early; the new Law on Investment and Decree 96/2026 provide clearer, faster procedures
Sector access and licensing conditions	Some sectors remain closed to foreign investors and others carry ownership or licensing conditions	Confirm sector status with local counsel at the outset and consider joint ventures where conditions apply
Banking and real estate sector	Moody's identifies banking and property as areas that could constrain further upgrades, despite its positive outlook	Conduct careful counterparty due diligence; ongoing reforms create opportunities for well-capitalised entrants in finance and property

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Vietnam's risk profile is that of a fast-growing, reform-minded economy with a diversified export base, rising investor confidence and a sovereign credit trajectory moving in the right direction: Moody's (Ba2) placed Vietnam on positive outlook in May 2026, describing it as the only Asia-Pacific economy with a positive outlook from the agency, while S&P and Fitch rate it BB+. Moody's cites a low and stable government debt load, with public debt forecast at 36–37% of GDP for end-2026, well within the National Assembly's 60% ceiling. The main external consideration is US trade policy, including the 12.5% Section 301 duty in place since July 2026 and pending investigations; Vietnam's constructive engagement with Washington and its wide network of trade agreements help mitigate this. Investors with US-facing exports should model tariff scenarios and maintain robust origin documentation, while those serving domestic and regional markets can draw on growth above 9%.

MARKET ACCESS

Vietnam has been a WTO member since 2007 and is a member of ASEAN, giving it a central place in Southeast Asian supply chains. It is a party to the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), and holds free trade agreements with the EU (EVFTA) and the UK (UKVFTA), providing preferential access to most major economies. The United States is its largest export market, taking $140 billion of goods in the first nine months of 2026, while the EU generated a $36.06 billion surplus and China is its largest source of imports. Deep-water ports at Hai Phong and Cai Mep–Thi Vai, the forthcoming Long Thanh International Airport and the planned 1,541 km North–South high-speed railway strengthen its role as a manufacturing and export hub.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
General Secretary and State President (To Lam) and the Government led by Prime Minister Le Minh Hung	Set the strategic reform and growth agenda, including the double-digit growth ambition and administrative streamlining	Primary reference point for Vietnam's strategic direction and major-project priorities
Ministry of Finance	Now responsible for investment policy and planning after absorbing the former Ministry of Planning and Investment, and oversees the State Securities Commission	Principal national counterpart for investment policy, incentives and capital-market matters
State Bank of Vietnam	Central bank; sets the refinancing rate, manages the dong and licenses banks, including within the financial centre	Relevant for currency, remittance and banking-sector matters
Vietnam International Financial Centre executive agencies (Ho Chi Minh City and Da Nang)	Operate the new financial centre, including its membership registration system launched in August 2026	Structuring venue for financial-services, fintech and cross-border transactions
Ministry of Industry and Trade	Leads trade policy, trade agreement implementation and energy-sector regulation	Key counterpart on market access, trade remedies and energy investment

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Ministry of Construction	Oversees transport and infrastructure, including the North–South high-speed railway	Relevant for infrastructure, engineering and construction opportunities
Provincial People's Committees and Departments of Finance	Issue investment and enterprise certificates and manage land, industrial parks and local incentives	Essential partners for site selection and project approvals

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The American Chamber of Commerce in Vietnam, the European Chamber of Commerce in Vietnam (EuroCham) and the British Chamber of Commerce Vietnam are the leading Western business associations, alongside the Vietnam Chamber of Commerce and Industry (VCCI) for domestic business liaison. The Vietnam Business Forum provides a regular platform for dialogue between foreign investors and the Government. Asian investor networks, including Japanese, Korean and Singaporean business associations, are highly active and offer practical intelligence on manufacturing supply chains. The World Bank, the Asian Development Bank and IFC maintain active programmes in infrastructure, energy and private-sector development, and the new Vietnam International Financial Centre is emerging as a networking hub for financial-services investment.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Vietnam suits a wide range of investors seeking exposure to one of Asia's fastest-growing economies: manufacturers in electronics, semiconductors, components and materials, particularly those that deepen local value added; logistics and infrastructure investors drawn by new ports, Long Thanh airport and the high-speed rail programme; financial-services and fintech investors using the Vietnam International Financial Centre; portfolio investors entering following the FTSE emerging-market upgrade; and consumer, retail and agro-processing investors serving a growing domestic market. Investors with significant US-bound exports should build tariff and origin-compliance planning into project economics.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the Ministry of Finance and target provincial authorities
Open dialogue with the Ministry of Finance and the relevant provincial Department of Finance to confirm incentives and procedures under the new Law on Investment and Decree 96/2026.

STEP 2: Select a zone that qualifies for expedited registration
Shortlist industrial parks and high-tech zones where the expedited route allows Investment Registration Certificates within about 15 working days.

STEP 3: Assess Vietnam International Financial Centre structuring
Consider the centre's tax incentives, foreign-exchange freedoms and choice of foreign law for financial-services and cross-border transactions.

STEP 4: Build trade-policy and origin planning into export strategy
Model US tariff scenarios, maintain robust rules-of-origin documentation and use EU, UK, CPTPP and RCEP access to diversify markets.

STEP 5: Connect with chambers and established investors
Use AmCham, EuroCham, the British Chamber of Commerce Vietnam and the Vietnam Business Forum to gain practical intelligence and government access.